

Employee Care Partners of Spouses with Parkinson’s Disease: Analysis of Patient and Care Partner (Direct Medical, Rx, and Total) Costs and Care Partner Lost Work Time

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Background

- In the United States,¹ Parkinson’s disease (PD) is the 2nd most common neurodegenerative disease with nearly 1 million people living with Parkinson’s disease and 1.2 million expected by 2030.
- While the overall incidence of Parkinson’s disease increases with age, ~4% of people are diagnosed during their working years, before age 50.
- Parkinson’s disease costs for employers include health care benefits for employees and dependent spouses, indirect costs for care partners (employee caregivers [CGs]) including unpaid time off for Family Medical Leaves (FMLs) and paid Discretionary Incidental Time-off (DITO) to care for spouse patients.
- The Society of Actuaries 2024 survey reported:²
 - 13% of male and female pre-retirees provide care or have provided care to loved ones who are not minor children, while 38% say they are unprepared to offer any help for a family member’s medical emergency or health issue
 - Caregivers are most concerned about the emotional and/or physical toll for male and female pre-retirees (36% and 26% respectively)

Objectives

- Examine annual medical, prescription (Rx), FML, and DITO trends for caregiver (care partner) employees of spouses with Parkinson’s disease.
- Examine medical and Rx claims for patients with Parkinson’s disease.

Study Population

- The Workpartners Research Reference Database (RRDb)³⁻⁸ contains
 - Health plan medical and Rx claims
 - Enhanced demographics (including race, marital status, salary, job type, full/part-time status, exempt/non-exempt status)
 - Absence and disability (short- and long-term), Workers’ Compensation claims (with durations and payments)
 - FML durations
- The RRDb includes over 5.5 million employees and dependents in all 50 states, from 2001 to present. Employees are linked to their dependents.
- The RRDb has been used in prior employee³⁻⁴ and caregiver⁵⁻⁸ research.

Methods

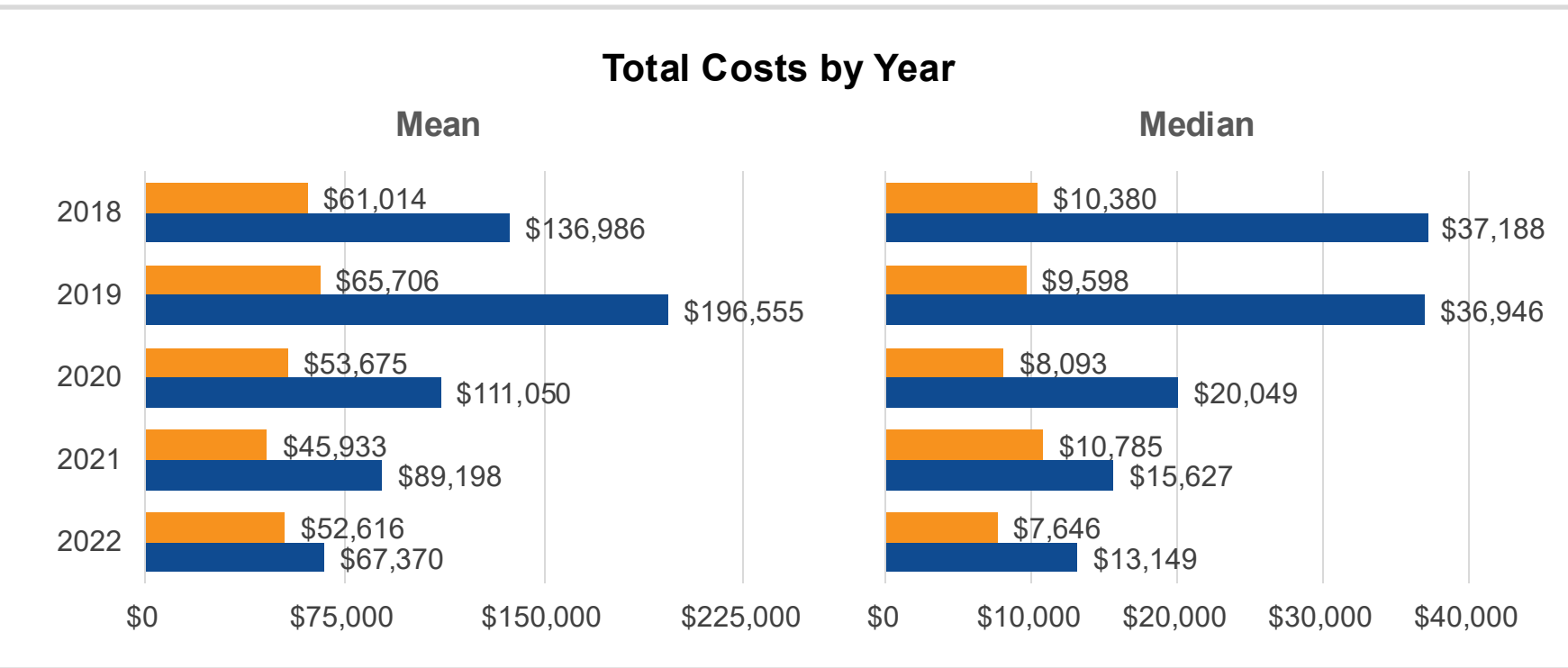
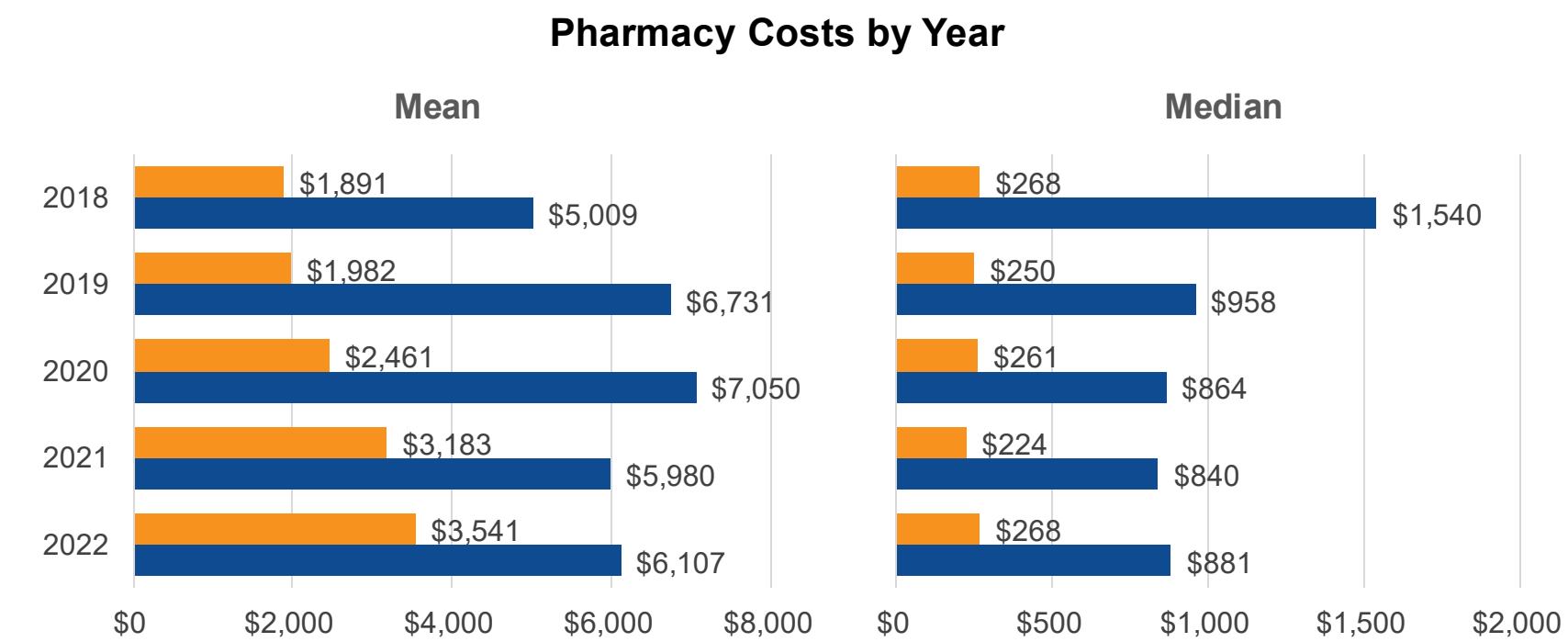
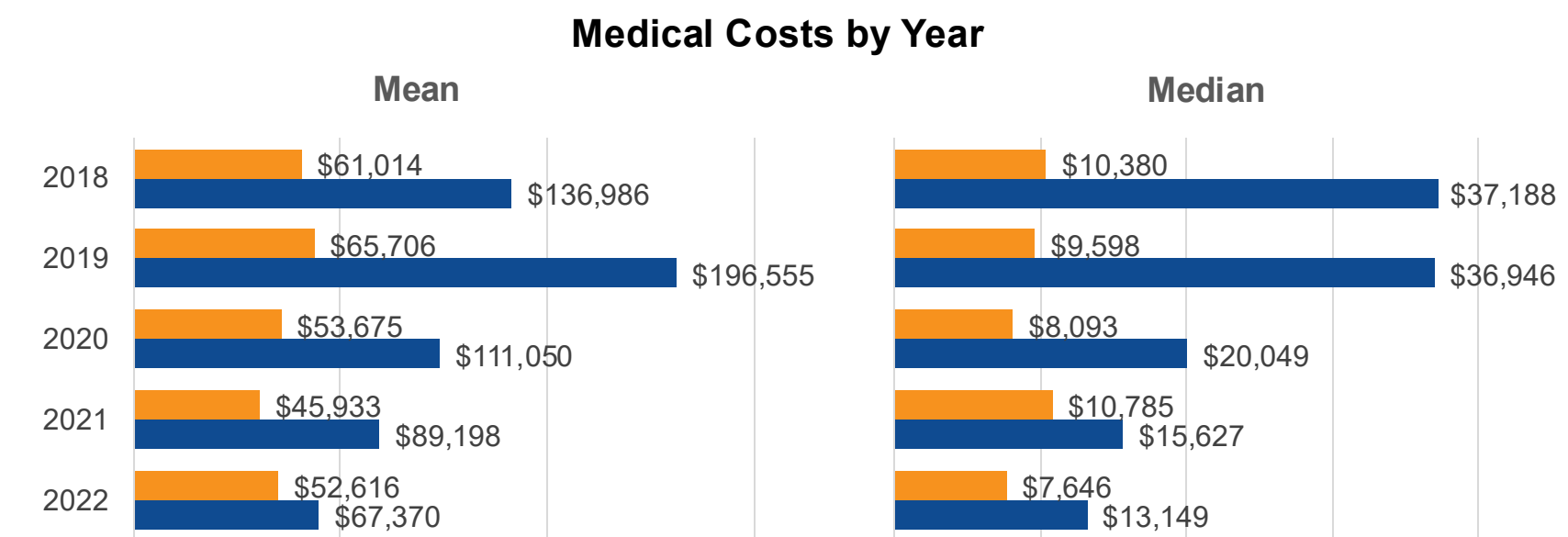
- Retrospective analysis of US patients in the RRDb (2018—2022).
- Patients** with Parkinson’s disease were identified by ICD-10 code G20.
- Patients** and **care partners** had ≥ 1 year continuous data following **patient’s** initial Dx (Index Year) and were analyzed based on Index Year.
- The following outcomes were reported based on the Index Year:
 - Caregiver:** FML claims filed, days missed under DITO and FML; per member per month (PMPM) medical, prescription, and total costs
 - Patient:** The % and trends of PMPM medical, prescription, and total costs
- Per patient per year (PPPY) costs adjusted to December 2023 US dollars.

Results

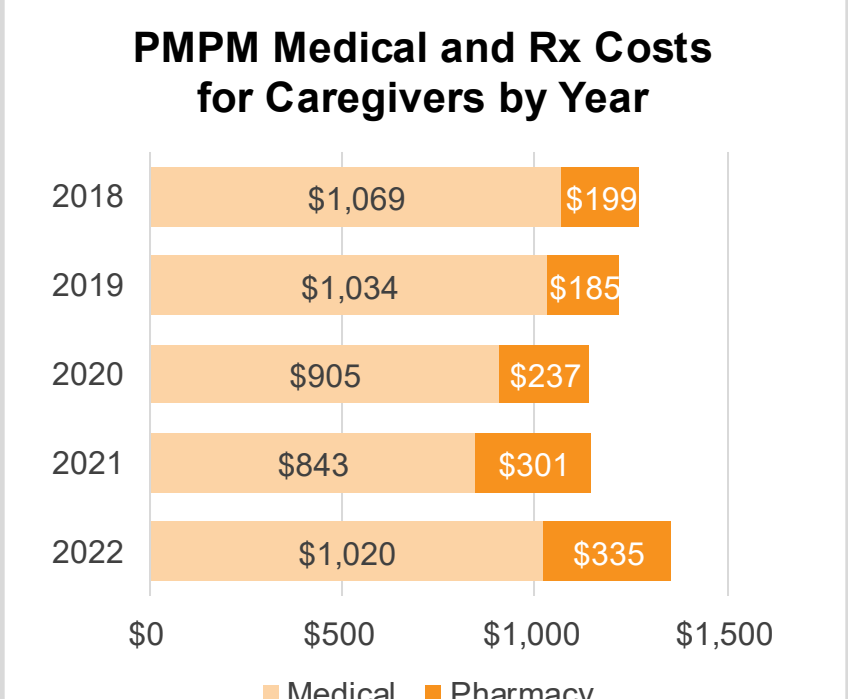
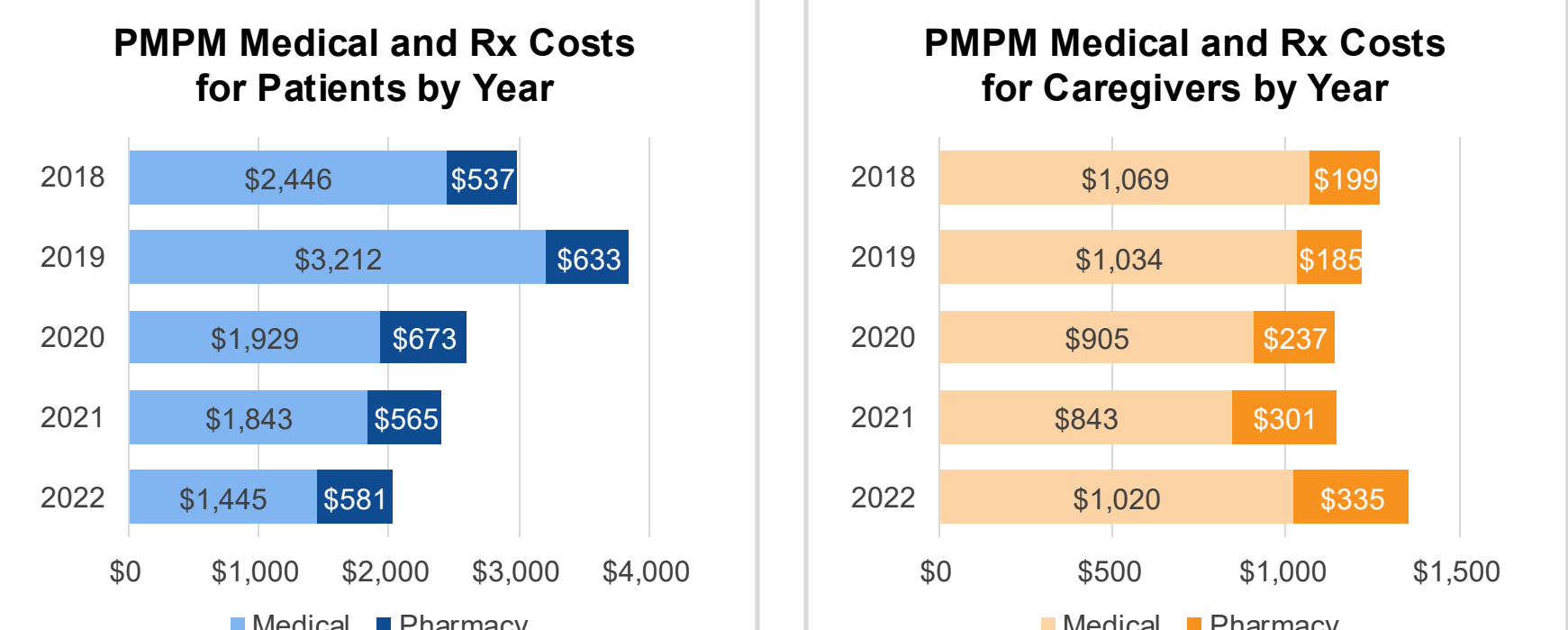
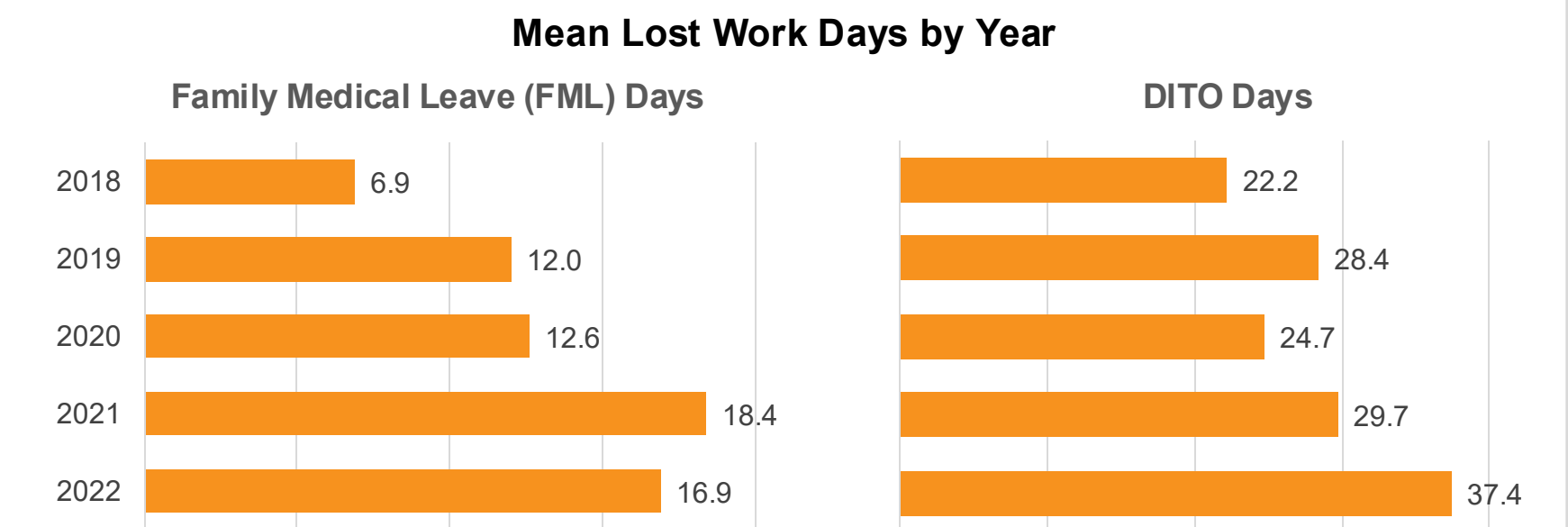
- We identified 1772 **care partners** and **patients** with Parkinson’s disease.
- New care partner-patient pairs increased 166% from 2018 (257) to 2022 (426).

Employee care partners and patients with Parkinson’s disease	Year				
	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Employee care partner pairs (total=1,772)	257	327	366	396	426
Employee					
Age (at index), Mean (S.D.)	57.1 (7.7)	57.2 (7.7)	56.6 (7.3)	56.4 (8.2)	56.5 (8.3)
Female, %	66%	64%	64%	61%	63%
Patient					
Age (at index), Mean (S.D.)	61.2 (8.6)	60.6 (10.4)	59.6 (11.2)	58.9 (12.2)	58.7 (12.0)
Female, %	34%	36%	37%	38%	36%

Legend: ■ Patient ■ Care partner



- Family medical leave (FML) claims were filed by 13% of the employee caregivers.



Conclusions

- Although Parkinson’s disease is often considered a disease of the elderly, the age of first diagnosis is decreasing, increasing the number of working age persons diagnosed.
- Although medical and Rx costs have declined since 2018, there has been
 - A significant increase in Family Medical Leave Absences (FMLA), leading to a loss of more than two weeks of worker productivity in 2021, 2022
 - An upward (though less linear) trend in DITO days

Limitations

- While this research was focused on employees caring for spouses, it was unknown if other support persons were available.

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